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Protect Girls Sports

Common sense is not merely a slogan; it is the faculty by which we perceive the plain truths of our existence. In the realm of athletics, a plain truth is currently under siege...

By Mark Greenstein | Opinion

Common sense is not merely a slogan; it is the faculty by which we perceive the plain truths of our existence. In the realm of athletics, a plain truth is currently under siege: that biological differences between the sexes matter, and that fairness requires we acknowledge them.

It has been over fifty years since Title IX was enacted. Its purpose was explicit and noble—to ensure that young women had the same opportunities as young men to compete, to strive, and to achieve glory on the playing field. It was a recognition that without distinct categories, female athletes would be effectively erased from the podium. Today, we face a peculiar regress where the very category of 'girls' sports' is being dismantled in the name of a new, abstract definition of inclusion.

Conserva-Tarian: Definition and Purpose

By CS 250 Founders and Publisher | Message

We welcome articles about civics, both public and private. With an expanding readership, we do hope to influence our national civics and politics. Contributors should email the publisher using firmconnect@gmail.com. These are especially welcome from those with intimate knowledge in a subject, but pure opinion pieces backed by reasoning are solid too.

Articles will be edited with a “Conserva-Tarian” overlay. And the expected readership is American. While American families, American businesses, American religiosity, and American government can and should again influence the world, the direct focus is here, and in particular New England.

Conserva-Taran is a term we trace to 2014. It is a melding of “conservative” and “libertarian” that very well defines the American creed. Since 1776, thoughtful Americans have generally shared a strong belief in: Tolerance for others, Individualism (not groups), Merit-ocracy (not blood lines), Property rights (not forced socialism), And Deism (at minimum, that we have a Creator).

This creed envelops almost all of us, from center-left Democrats, to Libertarians, to far-right Republicans. Though our elected leaders may squabble, we the people generally hold the above tenets.

The far-left, are not among “We the People”. They are by our definition, those who do not want American to succeed. Though they may profess patriotism, they are, but the definition above, un-American.

Common Sense 250 is for the rest of us. It is meant to extol virtuous Civics to Americans for the NEXT 250 years. We trace to Thomas Paine, but invoke modernity in having an online version follow the paper version 4 to 5 days later. The online version includes ripostes

May this herald resurgent journalism, and a resurgent United States of America.

The Patriot Way: Rebuilding Excellence

Actions speak louder than words. As Drake Maye takes the helm in New England, we look at the historical precedent for quiet leadership.

By Sports Desk | Sports

The New England Patriots have long been defined by a specific culture of accountability and preparation. With the arrival of Drake Maye, that culture faces its most significant test in a generation. Leadership in New England has never been about the loudest voice in the room, but the most prepared one.

As Maye begins his tenure, we examine why the region's sports identity is so intertwined with the values of grit and resilience. After five years in the wilderness, the rebound of the Patriots is more than just a football story; it's a testament to the idea that actions speak more than words. The region watches not just for wins, but for the restoration of a standard of excellence that defined the 'Patriot Way'.

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ICE Deportations: for New England Republicans, it's NOT an 80/20 Issue

“80-20 Issues” are the new hallmark for political pundits to note, and for political consultants to steer their candidates to elevating...

By Kemler Samuels | Politics

“80-20 Issues” are the new hallmark for political pundits to note, and for political consultants to steer their candidates to elevating. I am a volunteer consultant to all Northeast conservative candidates, and my wisdom for you is, ICE deportations are NOWHERE NEAR an 80-20 issue for New England Republicans.

While national polling MIGHT yield a 70+ percent favorability, please remember: nationwide polling absorbs New England, a mere 6% of the U.S. population, with the 94% elsewhere. Fervor for ICE deportations in Arizona, Texas, and Florida (together nearly 4x the population of New England) dwarfs the coolness that New England voters have.

As of mid-February 2026, ICE detentions have barely been vivid in New England. A five-day ICE intrusion in Lewiston Maine yielded the only widely-photographed mass arrests. Should ICE operations head to multiple New England cities in salient force, there are too many things that can go wrong. It will animate New England opinion against these stiff-armed deportations. Nice neighbors pulled from their homes, harsh detention of their children, scuffles at protests, and perhaps violence akin to that displayed in Minnesota all move the opinion of all but the most fervid "law-and-order" voters.

As for “law-and-order” leaders....right now, it’s not a good look. Those leading the ICE charge are not exactly “telegenic”: Greg Bovino (Patton without a war), Steven Miller, Kash Patel, and Ken Paxton. More telegenic, but also problematic: Tom Homan (calm and seemingly warm, but view the semi-criminality for which he got a “pardon”) Kristi Noem (telegenic, but her fabrications in defense of “following orders” are out-of-control)

And it will get worse. Another shooting during a deportation operation is almost inevitable. Videos of ICE taking good-but-for-their-immigration-status men from their homes can't possibly engender sympathy for the heavily-armed, still-masked SWAT-like teams. Photos of a crying child without her parents well-up almost all our sympathies. And while the cerebral can and should overwhelm policy, the emotional usually rules mass opinion.

Meanwhile, Republican rhetoric about ICE helps a very wily (and very telegenic) Gavin Newsom bring forth the clever, manipulative acts that also animate media for him and against sensible policy.

We lost the Vietnam war largely because of images. Our policy was rightly on the side of freedom, but the images of fire and blood overseas, and of roughed-up protesters at home, made the vast majority of Americans anti-conflict or at best unconcerned with how Vietnam was run. If ICE images seem similar, please take heed.

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Protect Girls Sports (Continued from Page 1)

We are told that to exclude biological males who identify as females from girls' sports is a form of bigotry. But let us apply the lamp of experience. Sports are discriminative by nature. We discriminate by age—we do not force 12-year-olds to wrestle 18-year-olds. We discriminate by weight in boxing and wrestling—we do not pit the featherweight against the heavyweight. We do this not out of malice,

When a biological male competes in female athletics, the competitive balance is shattered. The bone density, muscle mass, and lung capacity of a male athlete is simply not comparable to that of a female athlete. To ignore this is to tell every girl on the starting line that her effort, her discipline, and her dreams are secondary to the validation of another's personal identity.

The Town Hall: Democracy's Purest Form

By Sarah Miller | Civics

In hundreds of small towns across Vermont and New Hampshire, the first Tuesday in March isn't just another day; it's Town Meeting Day. This tradition represents the purest form of direct democracy remaining in the United States. It's a place where a single voice can change the course of a town's budget, and where disagreement is tempered by the fact that you will see your opponent at the grocery store tomorrow.

In an era of increasing polarization and digital siloization, the physical proximity of the town hall forces a level of civility that is often lost online. Here, civics is not an abstract concept; it is a lived experience of collective responsibility.

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Axe the Tax: A Legacy of Minimalist Government

Gov. Meldrim Thomson didn't just have a catchy slogan; he had a philosophy. We revisit the 'Axe the Tax' platform and why New Hampshire's advantage depends on it.

By Historical Archive | History

Meldrim Thomson served as Governor of New Hampshire from 1973 to 1979, but his influence is still felt in the state's fierce 'Live Free or Die' attitude. His 'Axe the Tax' mantra was more than a fiscal policy; it was a moral stance on the role of the state.

He believed that the power to tax was the power to destroy, and that a citizen's liberty was directly proportional to the money they were allowed to keep. Today, as regional tax burdens continue to rise, the Thomson approach remains a focal point for those seeking a more minimalist, less intrusive government in New England.

Restoring Civics in the Classroom

By Education Board | Education

For decades, civics education has been sidelined in favor of technical skills and standardized testing. The result is a generation that understands how to use a tablet but doesn't understand the separation of powers.

Restoring civics means more than memorizing dates; it means engaging with the primary documents of our founding—the papers of Paine, the speeches of Coolidge, and the debates of the Constitutional Convention. It means learning the difficult art of productive disagreement and understanding that the preservation of liberty requires an informed and active citizenry.

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ICE Deportations: for New England Republicans, it’s NOT an 80-20 Issue (Continued from Page 3)

A “hill to die on”? New England Republicans especially...are federally-run deportations your “hill to die on”? There are others to fight fervently for: Keeping babies alive Universal school choice Pro minimizing government, and Ending local Democrat Party hegemony.

In 2026, state government policy should be more important than any DC policy. DC issues are assuredly problematic, in part because Republicans in Congress are themselves divided, and in part because Trump floats a policy every month that is hard to defend. Stick to your state and local issues. Even if running for Congress, the last issue, about Democrats restricting our lives, taxing us wherever possible, and rewarding their specialty groups at our expense, is fulsome for weeks of podcasts and personal campaign appearances.

The RIGHT policy Here goes. With still fervor for the “law of the land”, even at the no-tolerance level, we can remove just as many illegals with ICE minimally on the sidelines while local police do the arrests.

When two officers gently meet an illegal child during a school lunch period, they can then call the mom saying “Senora, your son is in our custody. We see no evidence of his status as a “dreamer”. Do you and your husband want to come to our station to work this out?

When two officers meet an older illegal following hospital care or clinic treatment, a call goes to the family: “We have your abuela in custody. She will be sent to a detention facility unless you want to be self-deporting with her. Would you like to see us and hear your options with her?”

The Feds should reward them for good, surgical apprehensions. That effects the “lighter touch” that President Trump recently touted.

Local police arrests are also economical. It costs ICE nearly \$800 per official per day to work in Metro Minneapolis. The low-end estimate is \$18,000,000 a week; and the high-end estimate (from an unsupported Kristi Noem) of arrests per week is 500. That is \$36,000 per arrest.

So instead, how about paying that to local police, who almost certainly have better knowledge of where the illegals are and their activities. Even paying the local PDs half that brings their precinct over \$500,000 for every 30 people they turn over.

Additionally, consider Alternatives To Detention. Detention following arrest averages nearly 50 days before deportation, costs on average \$7500 more per detainee, and deprives both employer and employee of productivity. Ankle-monitoring is effective, while showing we mean business.

Notice that the above policy and tactics apply irrespective of whether Republicans desire deportation only from post-immigration criminals or to all non-legal immigrants. It thus bridges the “libertarian” wing among Republicans (those aroused only by criminality), the “overrepresentation of the border” voters. The differences among our groups alone make this nowhere near an 80-20 issue. Even this is a subject

Tariffs: The Surface Spark and the Undercurrent Decisions

By Mark Stewart, Greenpeace | Economy
When it comes to health insurance, the Affordable Care Act (ACA), the lack of tort reform, our inflating American dollar, fraud, and American dollar, fraud.
The few who support tariffs need to start again. I say “few” because almost nobody likes the consequences of tariffs, direct or indirect. Many who support President Trump align to approve of tariffs simply because Trump is behind it and they are convinced he’s playing 4D chess. Separate them, and there are few Americans who approve.

When it comes to health insurance, the Affordable Care Act (ACA), the lack of tort reform, our inflating American dollar, fraud, and several other key issues have put millions in an incredibly vulnerable position. A solution to the health insurance problem will be elusive; but American political leaders must face the challenge now – not later.

And where is the excess we lay out going? Not to the importer. Not to the American retailer. It’s to the U.S. government, a very UN-American proposition made to the Maine legislature’s Health Coverage, Insurance and Affordability Services Committee in November, turned off lawmakers to what is coming. For the 64,678 Mainers who get their insurance from Maine’s CoverME, the state-based health care exchange operated under the ACA, health care premiums are set to increase by an average of 77% from 2026 for households receiving the subsidy. The impact consequence is even worse, as foreign nations under reciprocal tariffs on U.S. exports. That has not happened in a long way yet, but in it takes is a popular leader to call to say “I’m standing up to Trump”. His consumers will then have THREE reasons to not buy from U.S. firms: • Higher prices to them. • Akin to war, they adopt “Don’t Buy American”. • New manufacturers form in those nations to for many Maine families, it means a much larger percentage of their income will go toward health insurance premiums – that is, if they even decide to continue coverage. Those in the highest income bracket who currently receive the EPTC will lose the subsidy completely. And according to the office that oversees the Maine Health Insurance Marketplace, that could add up to tens of thousands of dollars a year owners means less they can spend domestically. And if it’s dramatically less revenue, employees get laid off. That’s ZERO income for them and greatly reduced spending to businesses around them. One problem is the ACA, known to most as Obamacare, has been failing us for years. Higher subsidization of it through the American Rescue Plan Act of 2021 and then extended by the Inflation Reduction Act of 2022 only masked a problem that had been growing since its implementation in 2014. Just a year ago 600,000 Mainers with health insurance through an employer (including me) have already experienced the rollercoaster of double-digit rate increases over the past decade.

If the Trump Administration REALLY Wants Tariffs, Use Congress. Congress, should a majority in each House approve, has the sole power to raise or lower tariffs. In fact, the average annual cost of insurance for workers covered under an employer-sponsored plan was more than \$8,500 in 2013, the year

a boon: 15.3% of \$184,500 is just 9.4% of \$300,000; for the \$750,000 earner, the benefit is laughable: 15.3% of \$184,500 is a mere 3.76% of the \$750,000.

paycheck, is the ultimate way to fund statism. FDR started this morass, and 90 years later, it is a fixture for elected Democrats (and some Republicans).

same rate. If enacted, this would be a very temporary fix. Larson's solution neglects the pay-OUT aspect of Social Security. At some point, the high earners retire; then their benefits come due and they are HIGHER than the mid-income earner. Larson's plan might bring a quick infusion of money, but unless the accounting is even more monstrous, the ledger must show a very high expected pay-out for every high paying-in "contributor".

gird this: 1. The highest income earners are on average older and thus closer to withdrawal age. 2. Because they don't need the money, they are more likely to take their money out at age 59.5 than the lower income earner who calculates a bigger benefit by delaying withdrawals. 3. They are healthier, and far less likely to succumb to disease in their early 60s than lower income workers. 4. They are almost always married, so the Trust Fund will not be keeping their funds, as it does with unmarried workers who die young.

reason to keep his plans far away from a Congressional vote. If his plan is to fix by taxing workers at a higher rate, that's from the classic "tax-because-you-can" playbook.

inadequately from working until they dropped dead. Now, any attempt to “save” it means a delay of the inevitable collapse, and unfair confiscations along the way. OSDI and Medicare should be optional, if a payout is needed for current retirees and those close to retirement, then that should come from the Treasury, not from workers whose confiscated earnings will never be fairly repaid.

** Social Security was capped for two main reasons: 1) high earners rarely need the benefits in old age, and 2) high earners are influential

in policy-making; few legislators felt their well-heeled constituents (including political donors) would brook a 15.3% tax on themselves.